(2016), *Roohi* (2021) and *Badhaai Do* (2022)—follow this pattern. "Some stories give me an opportunity to talk about things I believe in and am proud of," he says. Not all of them may make a dent at the box office, but then Rao has carved a niche as a reliable actor who delivers the goods, no matter what. That, strangely, isn't a badge of honour he wants. "The 'actor' is a small part of the bigger picture. It is the film that matters most. No actor would want to hear, 'You were good, but the film didn't work for me.' I'd rather have people say, 'It's a great film.'" While the Film and Television Institute of India (FTII) graduate is grateful that a handful of his films can be described as "great", he also finds himself going further at a time when the phrase "content-driven" is overused by many but yet taken seriously by film studio heads. "More than any of that, it's about stories, actors playing characters on screen," he says.

Next year, Rao acts in his first film under the Dharma banner, *Mr & Mrs Mahi*, which also stars Janhvi Kapoor. The set of a Karan Johar production, Rao admits, does feel different, but he knows that the film is being made with the same "sincerity" as *Shahid*. The old 'Raj' isn't going anywhere, even as the stakes get bigger—story remains paramount; the more ingenious they are, the better. "You can't corrupt yourself by trying to be a commercial star. I am not in any race. I just want to grow as an actor, to explore and push myself. That's the only agenda." ■

Suhani Singh

CINEMA

GOING UP NORTH

Director **Mathukutty Xavier** is making his Hindi-language debut with *Mili*, a re-rendering of his Malayalam hit, *Helen*



After Mathukutty Xavier quit his well-paying job as a graphic designer, he wrote several scripts and pitched them to the biggest male actors in the Malayalam film industry. "Sometimes, they just weren't interested, but even when they were, I'd be told that they can start my film only after a year or two," he says. Xavier and his scriptwriting partner, Alfred Kurian Joseph, then moved to "Plan B"—to write a fresh story with a woman at the centre.

"That's how we landed on survival stories. When we started research, one of the articles I came across was about a girl in Atlanta who got trapped in a freezer." Xavier cast the then one-film-old Anna Ben as Helen in this eponymous survivalist thriller that went on to win two National Film Awards, including Best Debut Film of a Director. The film has since been remade into Tamil (*Anbirkiniyal*, 2021) and now, on November 4, it will release in Hindi as *Mili*, with Janhvi Kapoor essaying the role of the protagonist.

Set in Dehradun, the Hindi remake's screenplay has been adapted by Ritesh Shah, who has done films like *Airlift* (2016) and *Sardar Udham* (2021). "The story is, obviously, the same, but Ritesh sir has added nuances that help root it. Like the food joint where Mili works is called 'Doon's Kitchen' because we noticed that many establishments there [Dehradun]—from schools to shops—had 'Doon' in their name," says Xavier. The 29-year-old also spent some time in the terai town to understand this new world his story was set in.

To Xavier, directing the remake felt "like doing an entirely new film", and that was not just because of the changes that Shah brought to the script. "The budget for *Helen* was Rs 2.8 crore. I really had to cut corners when it came to technique. Like there's a camera I really wanted to use but couldn't because it cost Rs 5 lakh per day to just hire. But we managed to do that for *Mili*." One of the reasons Xavier decided to direct the Hindi remake was producer Boney Kapoor's unflinching faith in the original: "He told me to do exactly what I had done with the original story." And, then there was an opportunity to work with Janhvi. "At the time, I hadn't seen *Gunjan Saxena* (2020) or *Dhadak* (2018). I had seen Janhvi only in that one short from *Ghost Stories* (2020) directed by Zoya Akhtar and I thought it was a really good performance."

To understand the new world his film is set in, director **MATHUKUTTY XAVIER** spent some time in Dehradun



As he awaits the verdict on his Hindi debut, Xavier has, in the meanwhile, produced another Malayalam film that he has co-written with Joseph, who is making his directorial debut. He also has a script in place for what he wants to direct next. "It's a story that can be made in any language. I'll wait to see how *Mili* is received before deciding." ■

Karishma Upadhyay